Finding a topic, a research question and a datasite

Digital methods lecture 2

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Today's tasks

1. Come up with topics
2. Come up research questions
3. Find data sites

Today's mood

Positive, Curious, Daring(and a bit practical)

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Positive, Curious, Daring(and a bit practical)

What is a topic?

- Simply device a to concentrate your attention to some things and not others.
- We can use heuritics to change things around in order to see your topic in a new light

Topics please!

What is a topic?

- A broad theme
- An event
- A group
- An activity
- An idea/discourse
- A technology
- A location

My topic as X

- A broad theme
- An event
- A group
- An activity
- An idea/discourse
- A technology
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Theoretical and Empirical casing

1. Some start with a very empirical topic and need think about conceptually
2. Some start with a very theoretical topic and need to think about empirically

Casing: What is a topic a case of?

- Casing - from a empirical to a theoretical case
- Casing determines literature
- Casing opens up interesting questions

In groups take either your case or another case proposed and translate it into 2 or 3 different theoretical cases.

Case selection: What is an good empirical case of my topic?

- Casing from theoretical to empirical case(case selection).
- In the universe of possible cases what is your case good and bad for.
- Case-selection has analytical consequences.

Coming up with a Question

Types of questions?

1. Theory testing questions
2. Theory generating questions
3. Descriptive questions
4. Casual questions

	Theory Testing	**Theory Generating**
Descriptive	Is X characterised by Y? Does X correlate with Y?	What is X characterised by? What does X correlate with?
Causal	Does a rise in X cause a rise in Y?	What are the causes of Y? How does X cause Y?

Questions and quant/qual

- Qualitative analysis can be causal AND theory testing

Questions and quant/qual

- Qualitative analysis can be causal AND theory testing
- **Quantitative analysis can be descriptive AND exploratory**

Exploiting Digital Data and Mixed methods for productive questions

1. **New data for testing "old" theories**

"[J]ust as the invention of the telescope revolutionized the study of the heavens, so too by rendering the unmeasurable measurable, the technological revolution in mobile, Web, and Internet communications has the potential to revolutionize our understanding of ourselves and how we interact" (Watts 2012)

Exploiting Digital Data and Mixed methods for productive questions

1. New data for testing old theories

2. **New data for theory generation**

"induced data structures can surprise, challenging presumptions or pre-existing theory, and lead the social analyst to abductively generate new theory by imagining what would be socially required for those patterns to exist"(Evans and Aceves 2016).

Exploiting Digital Data and Mixed methods for productive questions

1. New data for testing old theories

2. New data for theory generation

3. **Mixed digital methods for theory testing**

MM approaches help address the uncertainties of testing theories old with digital data

Exploiting Digital Data and Mixed methods for productive questions

1. New data for testing old theories
2. New data for theory generation
3. Mixed digital methods for theory testing
4. **Mixed digital methods for theory generating**

MM approaches support the discovery and grounding of your theories.

Heuristics

1. Methods for creative problem-solving and problem-generation
2. For exploiting mixed digital data and methods to say something interesting
3. Used through-out the research process

Heuristics - Social Data Science *Data*

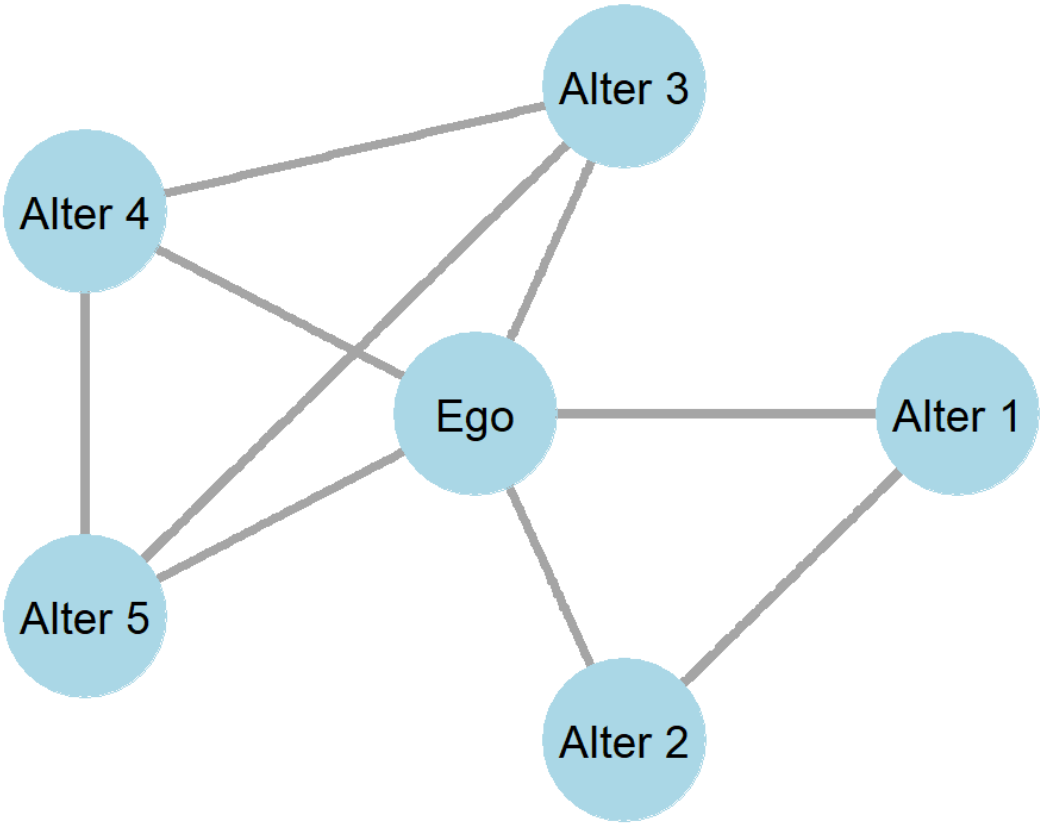
Digital Data Quality	Heuristics
Temporal data	setting in motion
Open text data	reconceptualize, changing context, interpretative
Nested data	changing levels, reconceptualize
Relational data	changing context, analogies
Big Data	spilting and lumping

Heuristics - Social Data Science *methods*.

Borrowing methods	Possibility	Assumption	Challenge
Topic modeling/word embedding	large-scale temporal analysis of culture	co-occurrence of words capture meaning	True?
Sentiment analysis	large-scale temporal individual emotional states	Social media message capture emotional states	True?
Network Analysis	whole networks, contagion, comparative network analysis	interactions and relation online = social relations	True?

Challenging assumption and asking new questions

1. What do we actually mean by something is a topic? When are you on or off topic? *Interpretative heuristic*
2. How do we use emotional words in public? *Constructivist heuristic*
3. What are the temporal patterns of relations on social media? *Setting in motion heuristic*


Alter 3
Alter 4
Ego
Alter 1
Alter 5
Alter 2

80
60
40
20
0
Aug 2015
Oct 2015
Dec 2015
Feb 2016
Apr 2016
Jun 2016
Aug 2016

Some examples of Heuristics

1. Changing levels

From social movement **organization** frames to patterns of groups **interaction**

Some examples of Heuristics

1. Changing levels

From **organization** culture to **interaction** culture

2. Reversal

From **Support** Networks to **Demand** Networks

Some examples of Heuristics

1. Changing levels

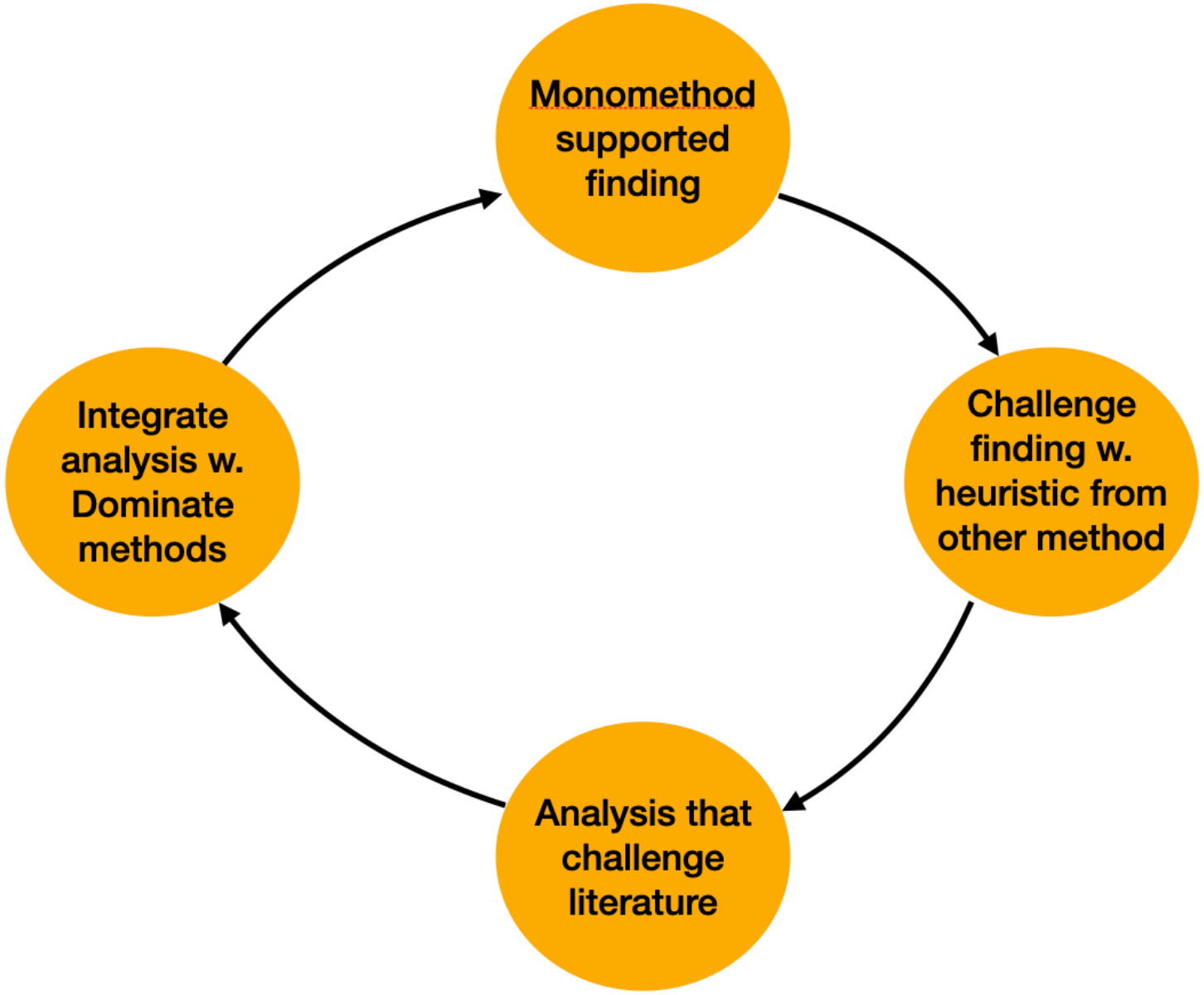
From **organization** culture to **interaction** culture

2. Reversal

From **Support** Networks to **Demand** Networks

3. Reconceptualizing

a. from deservingness **jugdements** to **practices**
b. **passive** public opinion to **mobilized** public opinion


Monomethod supported finding
Challenge finding w. heuristic from other method
Analysis that challenge literature
Integrate analysis w. Dominate methods

In groups discuss:

a) Heuritcs moves you could make in your project to challenge the dominate way of thinking about your topic?

b) Try heuritcs out on your case in order to see what perspectives it enables.

From topic to datasite(s)

Investigation process

1. **Simplification**: translate research question/topic into search terms, and then
2. **Search operations** that return options for further explorations, that require
3. **scouting operations** that provide initials observations on potentials datasites.
4. **Evaluation** and **selection** of datasite to become a part of the study.
5. **Collect** data form the datasite

Simplification and Search

Do not just put things into a search engine, think about how you can find a lead.

1. **Topical Words --> sites --> actors**
2. Follow Topical Actors --> words --> sites
3. Topical Platfoms/places --> words --> actors

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(Topical platfoms) Facebook as a database of Danish informal civil society

1. Device search term list for civil society focus
2. Search
3. Scout/read group names and descriptions
4. Update Search terms(return to step 1)

Milestone 1

- Description and justification of research topic and question
- Description and justification for central datasite(s)

(assignment 1, 1-2 pages – hand in to teacher team 24/4 at 12.00)

Exercise rooms

CSS 2-1-24 Møller, Anna Helene Kvist

CSS 2-1-55 Schischkin, Michael

CSS 2-2-55 Schana, Philipp

Next time: critically evaluate and select datasites